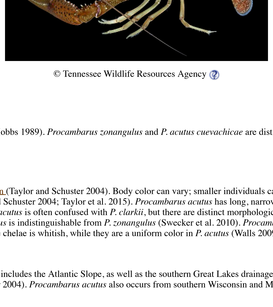
Procambarus acutus (White River crawfish)
Crustaceans-Crayfish
Native Transplant

Collection Info
Point Map
Species Profile
Animated Map



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Procambarus acutus (Girard, 1852)

Common name: White River crawfish

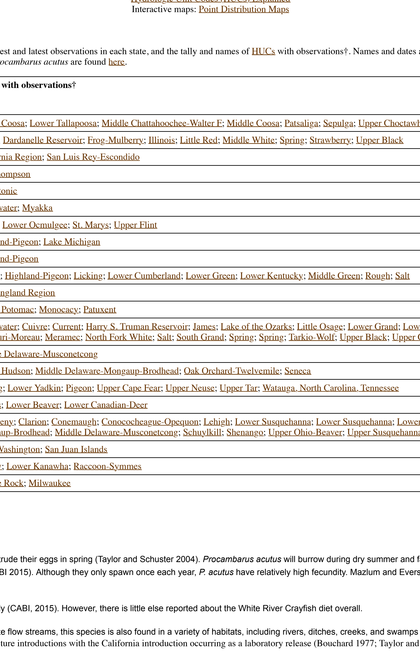
Synonyms and Other Names: *Procambarus acutus* is a species complex (Hobbs 1989). *Procambarus zonangulus* and *P. acutus cuevachicae* are distinct species that were formerly grouped with *P. acutus* (Taylor and Schuster 2004).

Taxonomy: available through ITIS

Identification: Body color is dark red with a black wedge on dorsal abdomen (Taylor and Schuster 2004). Body color can vary; smaller individuals can be brown with mottled spots (Taylor and Schuster 2004). Chelae possess numerous white tubercles and small tubercles cover the carapace (Taylor and Schuster 2004; Taylor et al. 2015). *Procambarus acutus* has long, narrow chelae with no space between dactyl and propodus when closed (Taylor and Schuster 2004). Areola is open, but narrow (Walls 2009). *Procambarus acutus* is often confused with *P. clarkii*, but there are distinct morphological differences, including a more open areola on *P. acutus* than on *P. clarkii* (Larson and Olden 2011). Without crayfish identification experience, *P. acutus* is indistinguishable from *P. zonangulus* (Sweecker et al. 2010). *Procambarus zonangulus* has tapered gonopods, while *P. acutus* gonopods are a constant width (Walls 2009). In most *P. zonangulus* the ventral surface of the chelae is whitish, while they are a uniform color in *P. acutus* (Walls 2009).

Size: 7-13 cm total length (USFWS, 2015)

Native Range: *Procambarus acutus* has a disjunct native distribution which includes the Atlantic Slope, as well as the southern Great Lakes drainages to the Gulf of America (Hobbs 1989; Taylor and Schuster 2004). On the Atlantic Slope, *P. acutus* occurs from Maine to Georgia (Taylor and Schuster 2004). *Procambarus acutus* also occurs from southern Wisconsin and Michigan through Kentucky and Missouri to western Texas and the Florida panhandle (Hobbs 1989; Taylor and Schuster 2004).



Hydrologic Unit Codes (HUCs) Explained
Interactive maps: Point Distribution Maps

Nonindigenous Occurrences:

Table 1. States with nonindigenous occurrences, the earliest and latest observations in each state, and the tally and names of HUCs with observations†. Names and dates are hyperlinked to their relevant specimen records. The list of references for all nonindigenous occurrences of *Procambarus acutus* are found here.

State	First Observed	Last Observed	Total HUCs with observations?	HUCs with observations†
AL	2006	2015	7	Lower Coosa; Lower Tallapoosa; Middle Chattahoochee-Walter F; Middle Coosa; Patsaliga; Sepulga; Upper Choctawhatchee
AR	1992	2019	9	Cache; Dardanelle Reservoir; Frog-Mulberry; Illinois; Little Red; Middle White; Spring; Strawberry; Upper Black
CA	1927	1927	2	California Region; San Luis Rey-Escondido
CO	1982	1982	1	Big Thompson
CT	2011	2011	1	Housatonic
FL	2005	2012	2	Blackwater; Myakka
GA	1938	2010	4	Broad; Lower Ocmulgee; St. Marys; Upper Flint
IL	1935	1975	2	Highland-Pigeon; Lake Michigan
IN	1993	2002	1	Highland-Pigeon
KY	1994	2004	9	Barren; Highland-Pigeon; Licking; Lower Cumberland; Lower Green; Lower Kentucky; Middle Green; Rough; Salt
ME	1989	1989	1	New England Region
MD	2010	2010	3	Lower Potomac; Monocacy; Patuxent
MO	1968	2022	23	Blackwater; Cuivre; Current; Harry S. Truman Reservoir; James; Lake of the Ozarks; Little Osage; Lower Grand; Lower Marais Des Cygnes; Lower Missouri; Lower Missouri-Moreau; Meramec; North Fork White; Salt; South Grand; Spring; Spring; Tarkio-Wolf; Upper Black; Upper Chariton; Upper Grand; Upper St. Francis; Whitewater
NJ	2014	2014	1	Middle Delaware-Musconetcong
NY	1996	2024	4	Lower Hudson; Middle Delaware-Mongaup-Brodhead; Oak Orchard-Twelvemile; Seneca
NC	1974	2001	7	Fishing; Lower Yadkin; Pigeon; Upper Cape Fear; Upper Neuse; Upper Tar; Watauga, North Carolina, Tennessee
OK	1993	1995	3	Illinois; Lower Beaver; Lower Canadian-Deer
PA	2004	2025	16	Allegheny; Clarion; Conemaugh; Conococheague-Opequon; Lehigh; Lower Susquehanna; Lower Susquehanna; Lower Susquehanna-Swatara; Mahoning; Middle Delaware-Mongaup-Brodhead; Middle Delaware-Musconetcong; Schuylkill; Shenango; Upper Ohio-Beaver; Upper Susquehanna-Lackawanna; Youghiogheny
WA	2009	2022	2	Lake Washington; San Juan Islands
WV	2004	2021	3	Gauley; Lower Kanawha; Raccoon-Symmes
WI	2011	2017	2	Middle Rock; Milwaukee

Table last updated 12/8/2025

† Populations may not be currently present.

Ecology:
White River crayfish mate in early spring and fall and extrude their eggs in spring (Taylor and Schuster 2004). *Procambarus acutus* will burrow during dry summer and fall seasons (Taylor and Schuster 2004). These burrows provide protection to females with eggs (Page 1985, CABI 2015). Although they only spawn once each year, *P. acutus* have relatively high fecundity. Mazlum and Eversole (2004) found that females may lay as many as 556 eggs depending on size and nutritional status.

P. acutus have a generalist diet and feed opportunistically (CABI, 2015). However, there is little else reported about the White River Crayfish diet overall.

While Hobbs (1989) reports *P. acutus* in slow to moderate flow streams, this species is also found in a variety of habitats, including rivers, ditches, creeks, and swamps (Taylor and Schuster 2004).
Means of Introduction: Probable bait bucket or aquaculture introductions with the California introduction occurring as a laboratory release (Bouchard 1977; Taylor and Schuster 2004).

Status: Established in **Alabama** (Illinois Natural History Survey 2017), **Arkansas** (Illinois Natural History Survey 2017), **Georgia** (Hobbs 1981; Skelton 2010), **Indiana** (Illinois Natural History Survey 2017), **Kentucky** (Taylor and Schuster 2004), **Maryland** (Sweecker et al. 2010), **Missouri** (Illinois DiStefano et al. 2015; Natural History Survey 2017), **North Carolina** (Cooper 2002; Illinois Natural History Survey 2017), **New York** (Mills et al. 1996; M. Caldwell, pers. comm.), **Pennsylvania** (K. Kelly, pers. comm.), **Wisconsin** (GBIF 2013), and **West Virginia** (Loughman 2007). Failed in **California** (Bouchard 1977), **Colorado** (Illinois Natural History Survey 2017), **Connecticut** (Beauchene 2011), **Florida** (GBIF 2013), and **Oklahoma** (Illinois Natural History Survey 2017). Unknown in **Massachusetts** and **Maine** (Hobbs 1989). Unknown in **Washington**, but most likely failed as no additional collections have been made since 2010 (Larson and Olden 2011).

Impact of Introduction: Unknown. However, DiStefano et al. (2015) reported that *P. acutus* may displace native crayfish.

Remarks: *Procambarus acutus* is an economically important crayfish used in aquaculture and as bait (Taylor and Schuster 2004).

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Other Resources:
US Fish and Wildlife Service Ecological Risk Screening Summary for Procambarus acutus

Great Lakes Waterlife

US Fish and Wildlife Service Ecological Risk Screening Summary for *Procambarus acutus*

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